

Jewels of ancient Egypt

When archaeologist Howard Carter opened the solid gold coffin of Tutankhamun in 1924, he lifted the lid on the culture of the ancient Egyptians, which dates back as far as 5000 BCE. Egyptian royal burial chambers were steeped in gold, in honour of the gods, and jewellery was placed on the bodies of the dead. Jewels often took the form of a *Wedjat* – a symbolic Eye of the god Horus – and animals that had religious symbolism.



Funerary mask of Tutankhamun

Inlaid with lapis lazuli and obsidian, this gold mask, c.1336–27 BCE, was said to protect the pharaoh so that his soul could be reborn.



Gold swivel ring

This ring features a hinged carving of a sphinx and symbols intended to protect the wearer.



Scarab pectoral

This gold, lapis lazuli, carnelian, and turquoise pectoral from c.1361–1352 BCE takes the form of a scarab beetle.

Vulture collar

This gold vulture, c.1550–1298 BCE, is clutching a *shen* (a ring with a short bar), the symbol for eternity.

